

library automation and networking solutions, enterprise IT solutions, FOSS-based services in specialised domains, etc. We have also helped get some visibility for the Indian FOSS scene at international fora like the Open World Forum, Paris, where NRCFOSS is a Program Committee Member.

In short, my journey through FOSS runs parallel to the work of NRCFOSS.

"There doesn't seem to be a clear short to medium term economic advantage of adequate value to motivate many companies to move to FOSS, wholeheartedly."

Q What prompted you to come out with a distance learning course on open source?

Primarily, I see the online M.Sc. (CS-FOSS) Program as being in close continuity with our ongoing campaign that promotes FOSS in higher education across India. We believe that, with the limited human resources in FOSS that we have at our disposal, there is no way we can scale up our operations to produce, say, tens of thousands of FOSS-qualified personnel for the country. But this is some thing we know we can achieve through the online mode that we have just launched, provided of course enough resources are available for promoting the program. It is here that entities like *LFY* that are committed to FOSS promotion can be of immense value to the success of this programme.

The other strong motivation for Anna University to encourage this online programme proposed by us was to try and move more of the teaching-learning processes online from the largely paper-brick-mortar mode—the direction that all education is bound to take, as time rolls on. FOSS, with its emphasis on doing-and-learning and being more oriented towards the learner (as against being teacher-oriented) also happens to be the ideal subject for a university to move online. It must be admitted right away that FOSS promotion in its 'pure and unadulterated' form is not the only objective of our online programme.

Ultimately, being a publicly funded state university with a strong social commitment, the online programme has to be so structured and managed that an average hardworking and motivated student without any prior FOSS exposure should have a very good chance of clearing the course and finding a placement in the software or IT job market.

A major technical university like Anna University coming up with a new degree programme is a complex process, and is subject to very close scrutiny. So it will rarely be that a programme like this gets launched for just a single reason. Given below are excerpts from our brochure (you can read it online) concerning our objectives:

- Evolve an affordable mode of imparting quality software/IT education at the university level that can scale with the future needs of the industry and society in a cost effective manner.

- Train the students formally in the philosophy, approaches, methods, technologies, tools and solutions of FOSS so that they can bring in innovation and creativity into the industry, leading to quality IT products and solutions that are affordable to the masses. The programme would help address the needs of the industry and the government for well trained manpower in FOSS.
 - Impart software/IT knowledge and skills to large numbers of students without sacrificing quality, by the use of effective online, Web-based and interactive processes and techniques that are already in use across the world.
 - Impart a high level of 'industry readiness' to the students by basing all teaching and learning on the use of proven real-world products, technologies, processes and standards from the FOSS domain – the learning environment that the students see will not be fundamentally different from the industry environment as far as the software packages and tools used are concerned.
 - Realise and deploy all parts of the online programme (content creation, content delivery, interactivity, evaluation, etc) using available FOSS products and solutions so as to make the programme itself a powerful demonstration of how mature today's FOSS technologies and products are.
 - Provide an opportunity to non-software/IT graduates, including working people from all over the country, to acquire a software/IT degree from a reputed university in a flexible manner. The software/IT industry could also use this programme to equip their engineers with specialised FOSS skills without having to send them away to class rooms.
- Despite the strong emphasis on FOSS, it is expected that the graduates of this programme would fit into the broad needs of the Indian software/IT market just like those with BEs, B Techs, MCAs and other qualifications from the regular programmes.

Q If you look at the Indian scene, the students and developers here are not the major contributors to open source. Do you think this initiative will help in increasing their contributions?

In a certain simple (simplicistic) way, if there are more young people entering the FOSS domain with a good formal grounding in it, which is what this programme aims to do, then certainly it is likely to improve the scene you have mentioned. But from what I have said earlier and elsewhere in this interview, I hope you now have a better idea of where we and this programme are coming from.

We all do share your concern on the subject you are mentioning, but having been associated with advanced research for many decades, I can assure you that the problem of the very narrow base of originality and creativity in India that you are alluding to is not limited to just the FOSS field alone, and the problem does have deeper roots than what is commonly portrayed. It is however possible that FOSS is an area where it is perhaps easier to address, and if our programme helps in that direction, we would be quite pleased!